

ANI

ASKING FOR IDEAS
Ajay Rai pays homage to Indira Gandhi after being appointed UP Congress chief, Aug. 24

UTTAR PRADESH

GIVING MUSLIMS A HAND

By Prashant Srivastava

In a state where it has largely been relegated to a position of irrelevancy, the Congress is trying hard to get back into contention with an extravagant nod at its old 'big tent' politics. Back in the day, that phrase connoted a space capacious enough to accommodate everyone, including the minorities. But after decades of being targeted by the BJP for 'Muslim appeasement', the Congress had often appeared mortified of inviting that charge. Not any more, it seems. On October 27, Uttar Pradesh Congress chief Ajay Rai strode up purposefully to Sitapur jail to meet Samajwadi Party leader Azam Khan, whose esteem among local Muslims matches his controversy index generally. When jail authorities denied him permission, it prompted a sit-in outside the jail gates. Rai was making a larger symbolic point: that the Congress is ready to stand with the Muslims in their distress. Even if the beneficiary of this "humanitarian" gesture was the Rampur strongman who, Rai alleged, is being harassed by the ruling BJP in UP to "settle political scores". Khan was sentenced to a seven-year jail term in a 2019 fake birth certificate case along with his wife and son.

The Congress's discovery of its capacity for demonstrative sympathy towards a high-profile Muslim figure is neither untimely nor out of place. Muslims, nearly 20 per cent of the state's population and who influence the outcome in 34 out of 80 Lok Sabha constituencies in UP, are seen as sunk in a spot of political despair under Yogi Adityanath's Hindutva regime. And as such, are exhibiting some mobility in voting behaviour, exploring options beyond the Samajwadi Party (SP), its usual refuge. Mayawati's Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) had made a conspicuous play for Muslim votes during the local body polls in May. Other parties like the AIMIM (All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen), too, are eyeing the same base. Under the circumstances, it's no surprise the Congress, too, may fancy its chances. A blanket Muslim vote in Karnataka has raised hopes of a like swing in

BEFORE THE 2024 POLLS, CONGRESS IS FOCUSING ON ITS OLD VOTE BANK OF MUSLIMS, PLUS DALITS, BRAHMINS